THE MODI FACTOR Prime Minister Narendra Modi at a public meeting in Bastar, Apr. 8

and Kanker will hold elections in the second phase on April 26 and the seven remaining seats in Chhattisgarh go to the polls on May 7. The counting of votes will take place on June 4. The Congress has taken care to play its cards well, fielding candidates who combine political gravitas with the right caste arithmetic. "PM Modi remains the single-largest factor for the BJP in Chhattisgarh, as in other states. However, the Congress, by choosing strong local candidates successfully, has sown the idea that there is going to be a real contest in certain seats, and victory [for the BJP] is not a foregone conclusion," says Sudeep Shrivastava, political analyst and senior advocate at the Chhattisgarh High Court.

This seems especially true in seats like Bastar, Kanker, Rajnandgaon, Janjgir-Champa and Korba, where the Congress is perceived to have a competitive critical mass vis-a-vis the BJP, unlike in Raipur, Bilaspur, Mahasamund, Durg, Surguja and Raigarh where the latter is seen to have a clear advantage. The forecast is partly based on the performance of the 2019 election in which the Congress had won Bastar and Korba and lost Kanker by a small margin of 6,914 votes.

The voter turnout in Bastar—where one Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) jawan was killed on polling day in an accidental grenade explosion and an assistant commandant of the CRPF was injured when an IED allegedly planted by Naxals went off—was 68.3 per cent. This year, the Congress fielded seasoned politician and former minister Kawasi Lakhma in Bastar. He was pitted against the BJP's Mahesh Kashyap, a fresh face. In Kanker, the Congress candidate is Biresh Thakur, son of late Congress MLA Satyanarayan Singh Thakur. Biresh, who had contested unsuccessfully from the same seat in 2019, has been active in the area in the past five years and expects to benefit from constituency-level anti-incumbency. Perhaps in an attempt to counter this, the BJP candidate here is Bhojraj Nag, who replaces sitting party MP Mohan Mandavi. In Rajnandgaon, the Congress has fielded former CM Bhupesh Baghel, who is not just expected to secure the support of his Kurmi caste but also get the votes of other farming communities owing to his pro-agriculture initiatives as CM between 2018 and 2023. He had attained good popularity during his chief ministerial stint, and the Congress's assembly poll defeat last year is usually ascribed to the BJP's superior election management and Congress infighting—not any individual deficit. Moreover, Santosh Pandey, the BJP's sitting MP who has been fielded again from the seat, is facing a degree of anti-incumbency, say political observers.

What works for the two parties

BHARATIYA JANATA PARTY

- **The Modi factor. There appears to be no viable alternative to the PM, making him the single-largest poll plank for BJP**
- **Well-oiled BJP election machinery and organisation, which has recently delivered Chhattisgarh to the party in the 2023 assembly election. Also, more financial muscle**
- **Delivery on major election promises made ahead of last year's assembly polls**

CONGRESS

- **The Congress manifesto is said to be finding resonance among women voters and youth**
- **Presence of traditional vote bank of Congress in the state among tribals and Scheduled Castes**
- **Better social engineering on display in ticket distribution**

Further, in keeping with what appears to be a carefully drawn-up list of candidates, the Congress has given tickets to two members of the influential Sahu community in the state, whereas the BJP has given ticket to only one. The move seems to be an attempt by the opposition party to hunt right inside the rival's territory—Sahus, a part of the other backward classes (OBCs), have traditionally voted for the BJP and are believed to have been a major contributing factor to its victory in the 2023 assembly election. Similarly, the Gonds, said to account for around 55 per cent of the state's tribal population and the single-largest tribal group in the state, have also gone unrepresented in the BJP's ticket distribution. The party has instead fielded non-Gond tribals in the four seats of Kanker, Bastar, Surguja and Raigarh, which are reserved for candidates from the Scheduled Tribes (ST). While the Congress is doing its best to use this against the ruling party—it has fielded Gond candidates in all four seats—the BJP in its campaign is seeking credit for giving the state its first tribal CM. Vishnu Deo Sai is a member of the Kanwar tribal community, with a sizeable presence in northern districts like Surguja.

The saffron party is also seek-